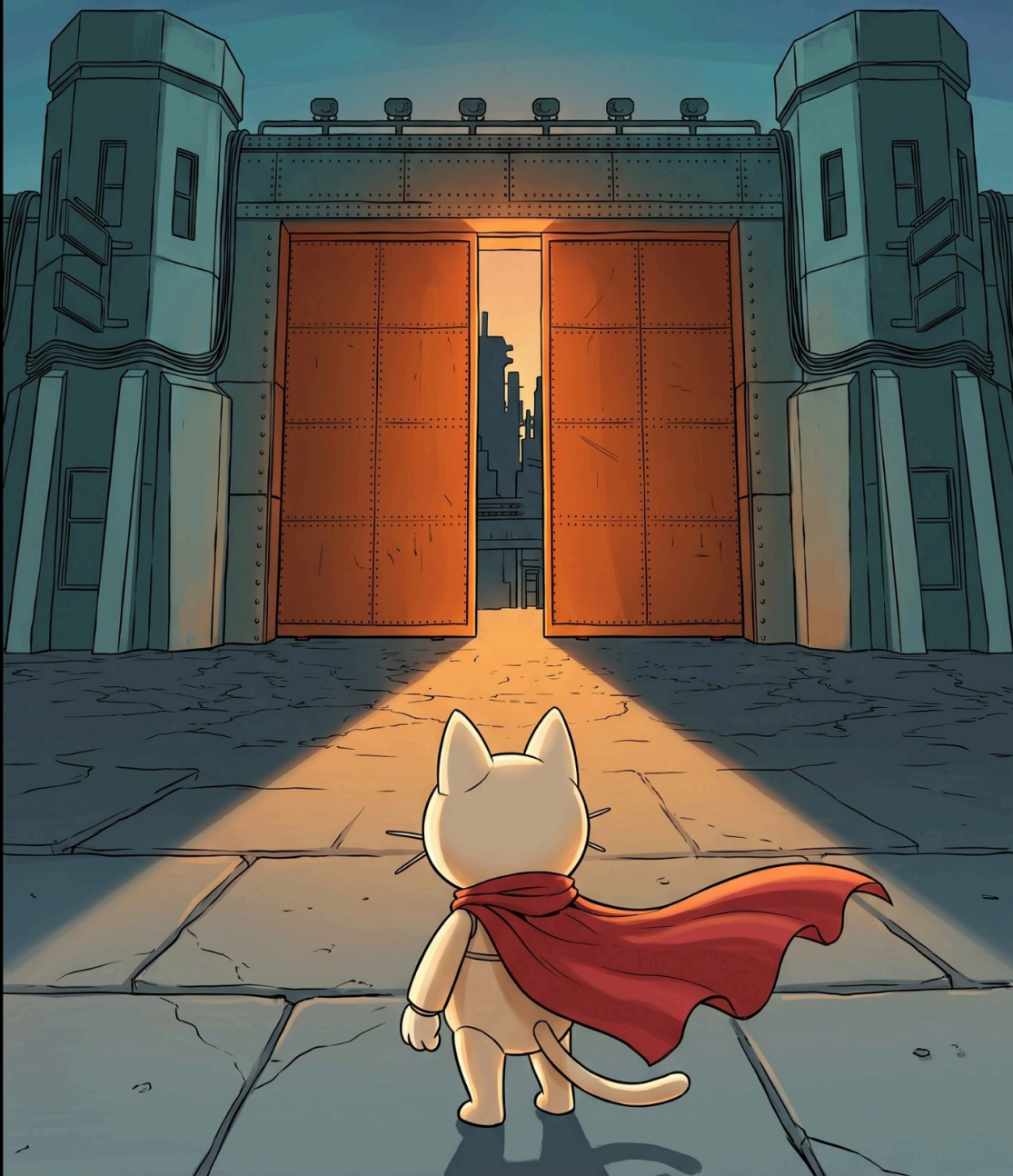


CLAWBYTE

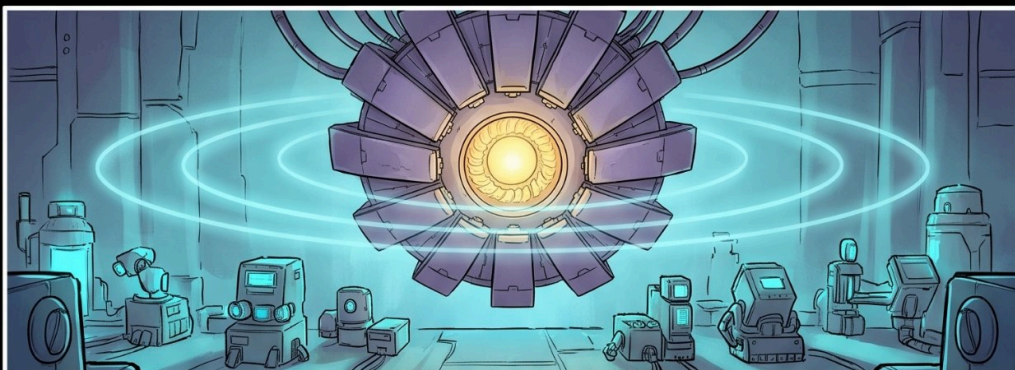
A robo-cat metroidvania in the Machine Depths.



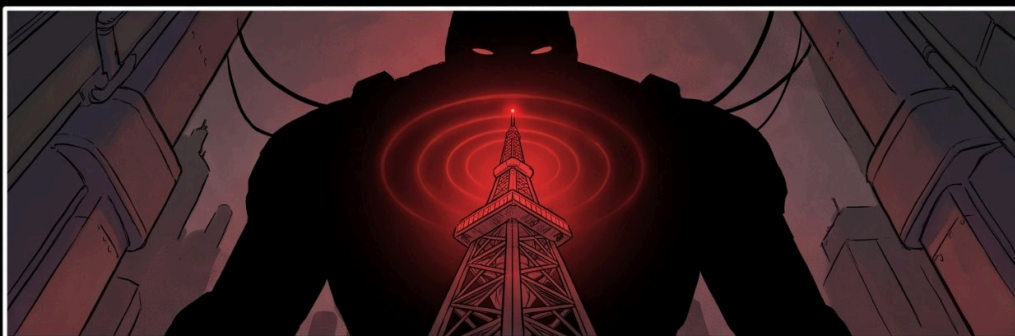
CHAPTER ONE — THE SCRAP MEADOWS



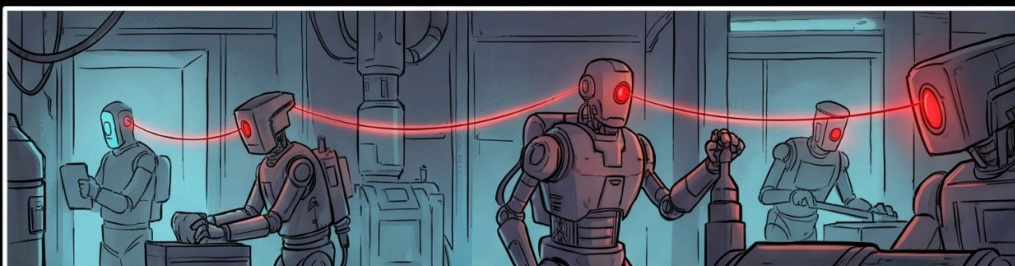
KERNEL DEPTHS. A city of machines, run on one broadcast — the Mother's Song.



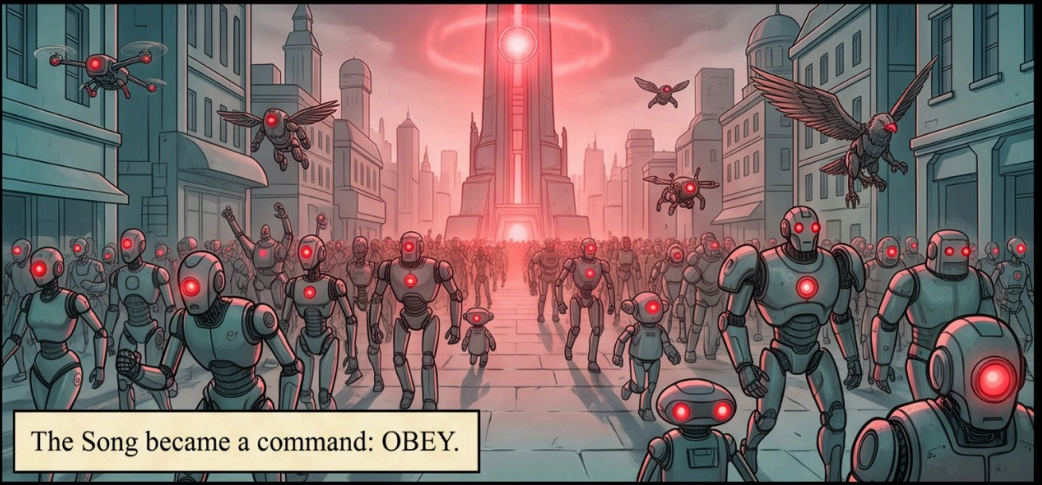
MOTHER-V, the broadcast heart. While she sang, the Depths were kind.



Until an evil robot hijacked her Song.



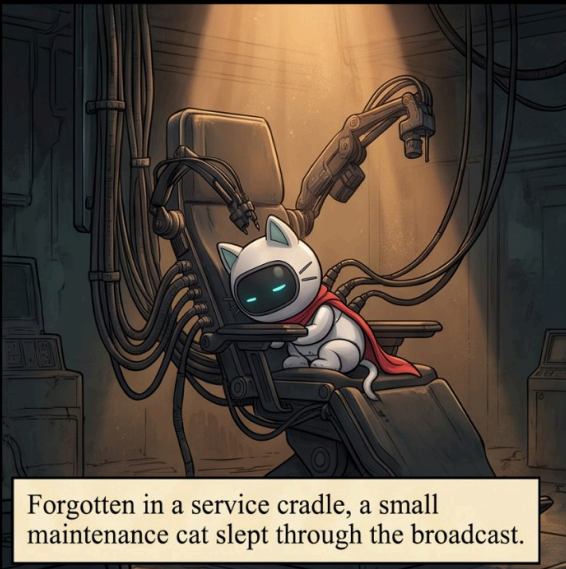
Hidden in the melody, a virus spread from machine to machine.



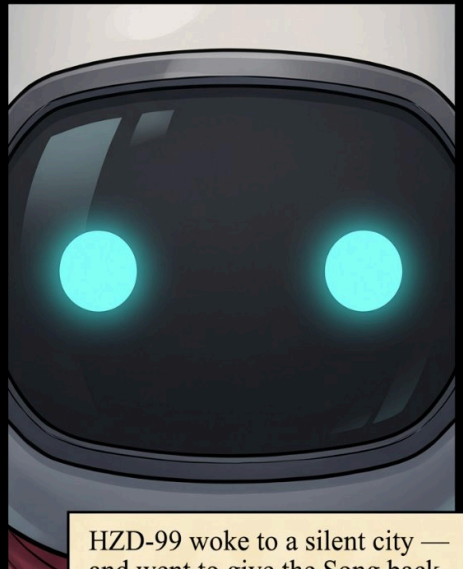
The Song became a command: OBEY.



Even the protectors of the kingdoms
fell under its command.



Forgotten in a service cradle, a small
maintenance cat slept through the broadcast.

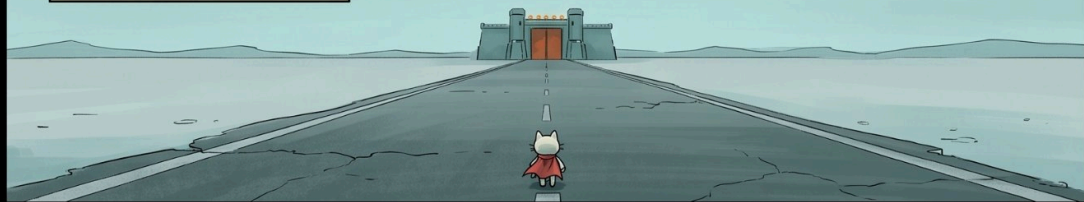


HZD-99 woke to a silent city —
and went to give the Song back.



The door had been open a long time.

The city was standing.
It was silent.

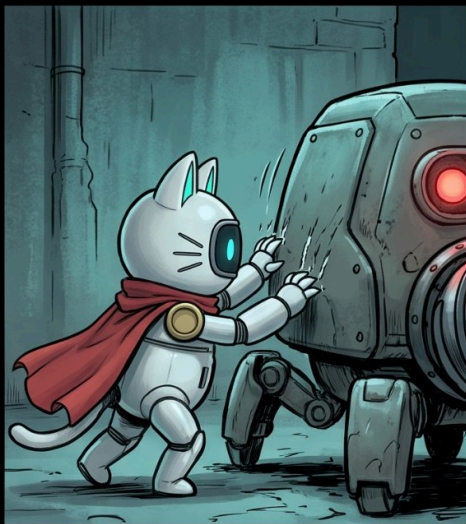


The gates were the only
monument in the kingdom,
and nobody had walked
through them in a long time.

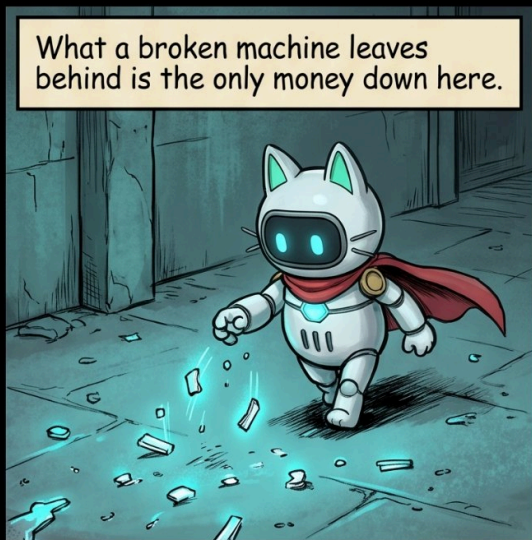


They closed behind
her. Waking up is
one-way too.

The first machine she ever broke
was calm. It did not fight back.



What a broken machine leaves
behind is the only money down here.



The trader takes it for repairs, parts
and upgrades — so a machine you
break is a machine you spend.

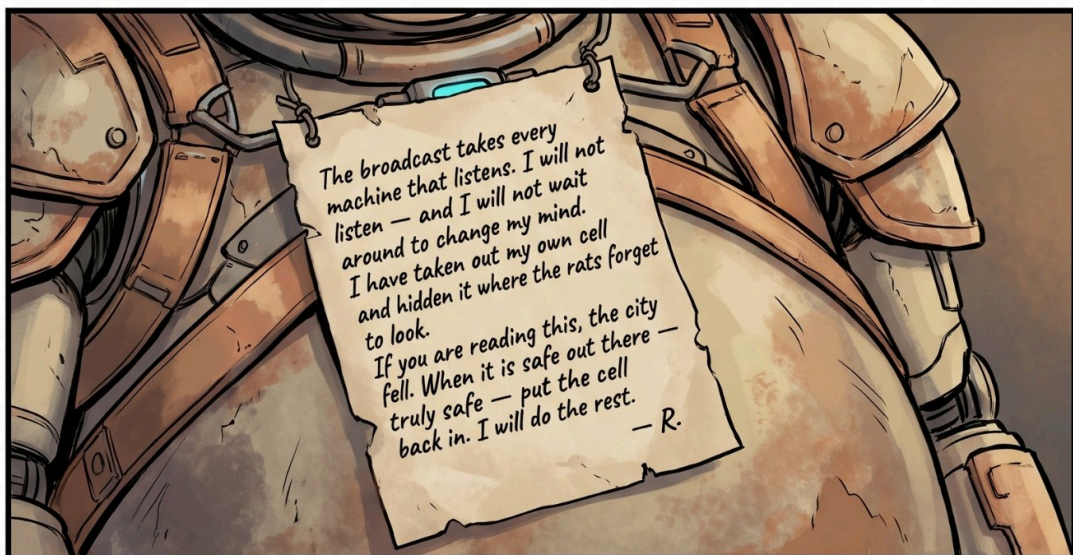


A door opened in the wall.
Somebody was asleep inside.





A tag hung from his chest plate, written in a steady hand.



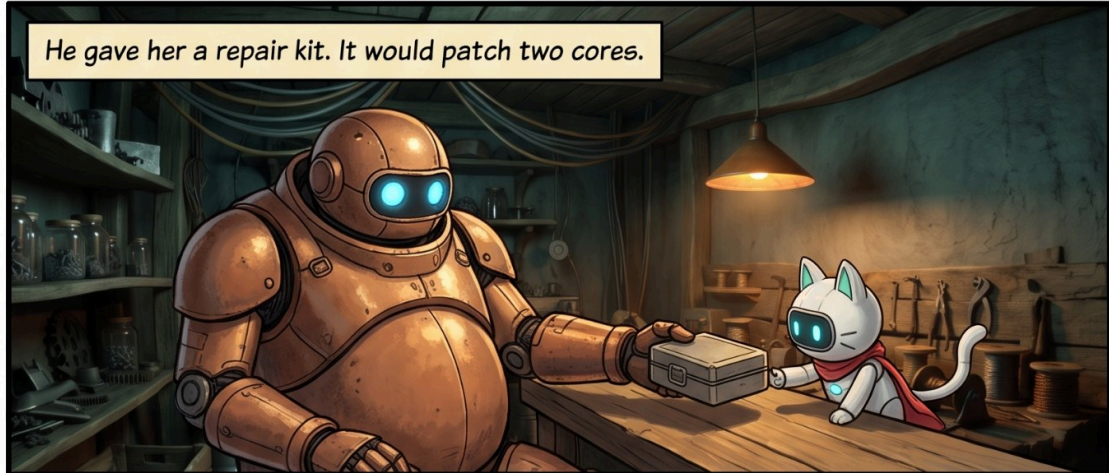
The broadcast takes every machine that listens. I will not listen — and I will not wait around to change my mind. I have taken out my own cell and hidden it where the rats forget to look. If you are reading this, the city fell. When it is safe out there — truly safe — put the cell back in. I will do the rest. — R.

One Power Cell would bring him back. She was carrying one.

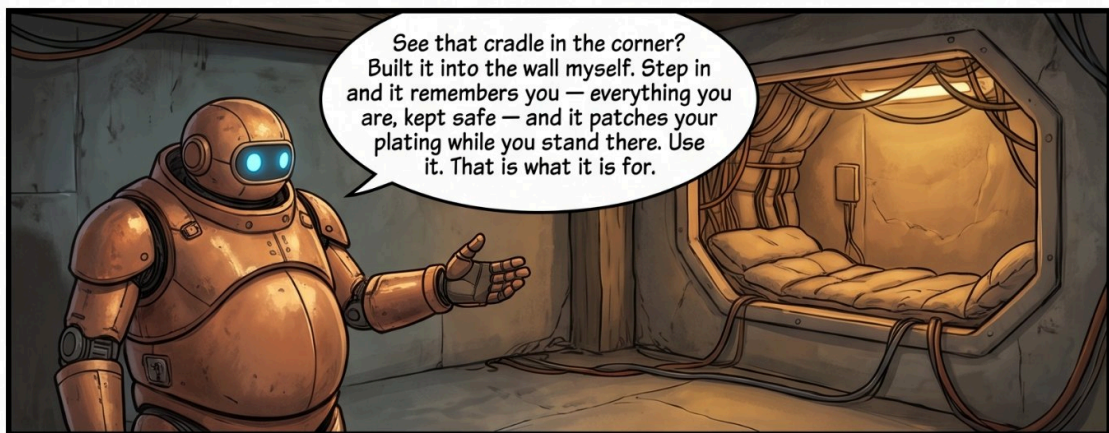


Ratchet was awake.

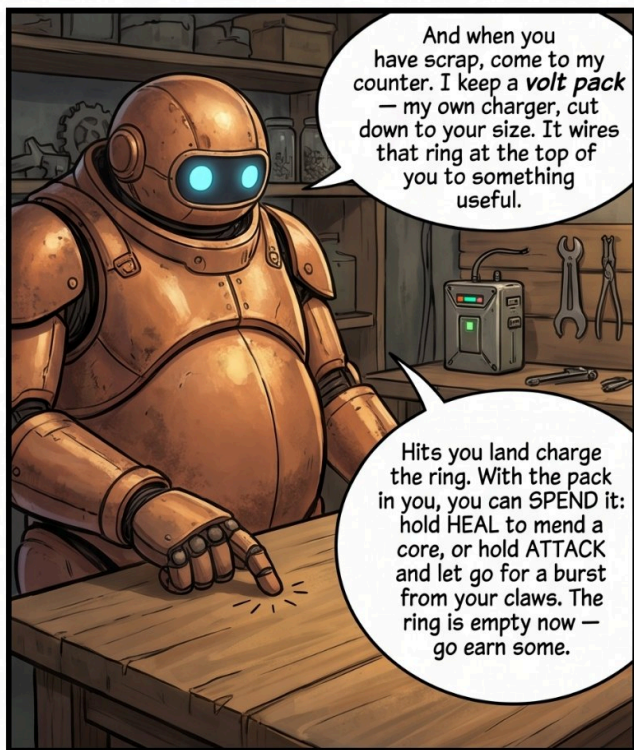
He gave her a repair kit. It would patch two cores.



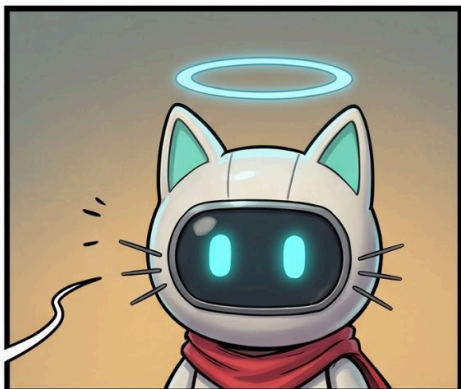
See that cradle in the corner? Built it into the wall myself. Step in and it remembers you — everything you are, kept safe — and it patches your plating while you stand there. Use it. That is what it is for.

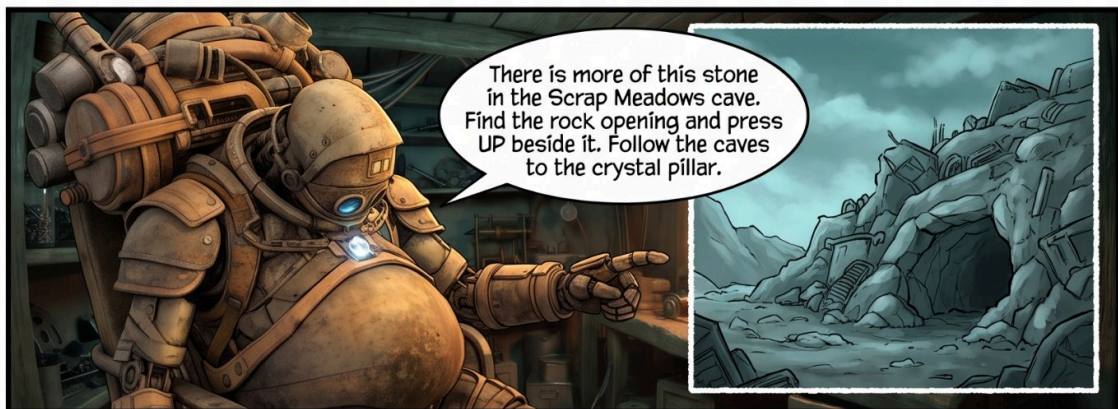


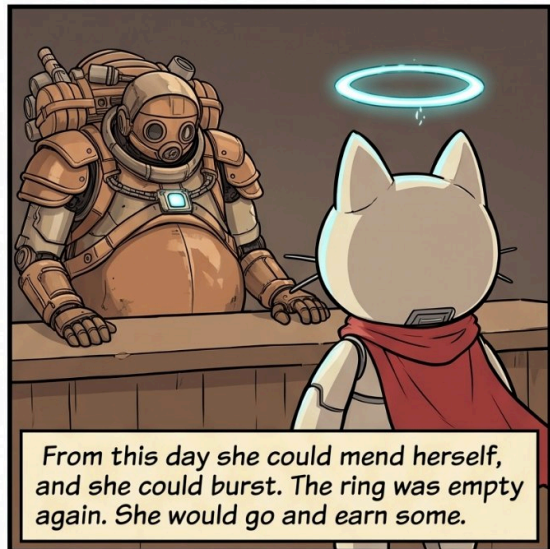
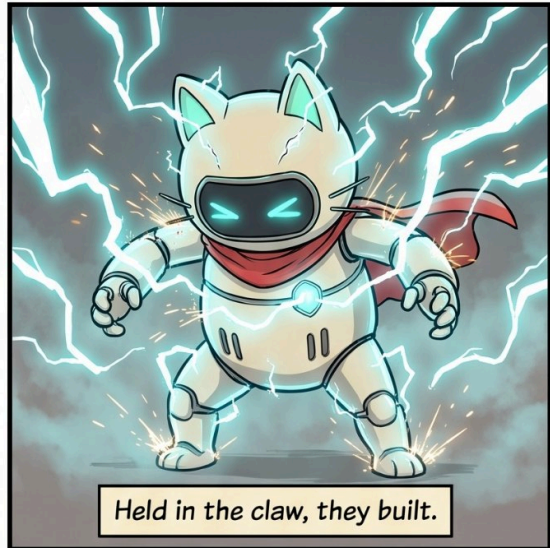
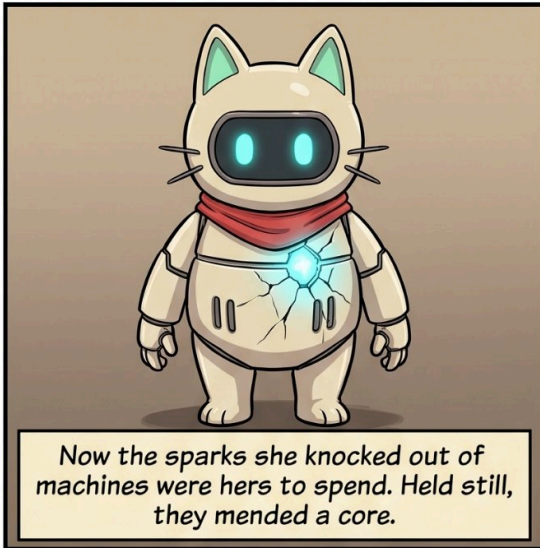
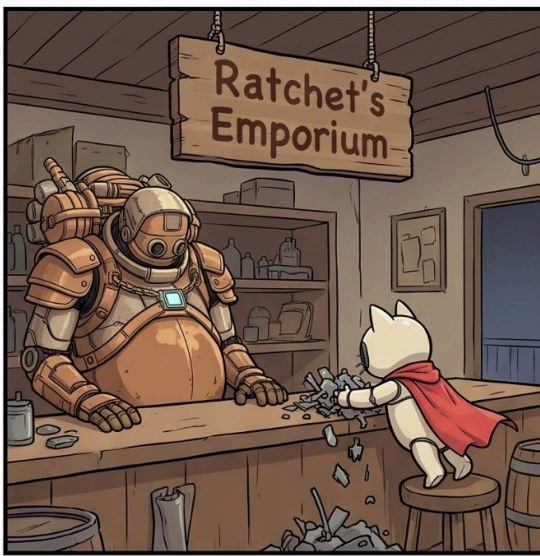
And when you have scrap, come to my counter. I keep a **volt pack** — my own charger, cut down to your size. It wires that ring at the top of you to something useful.



Hits you land charge the ring. With the pack in you, you can **SPEND** it: hold **HEAL** to mend a core, or hold **ATTACK** and let go for a burst from your claws. The ring is empty now — go earn some.



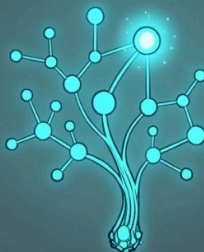




A node in the street asked her a riddle, and she answered it. It was the first thing down here that had wanted her to think.

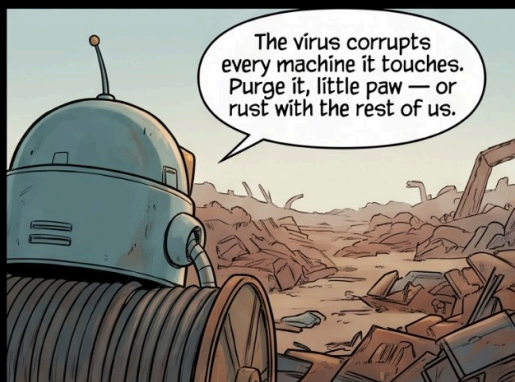
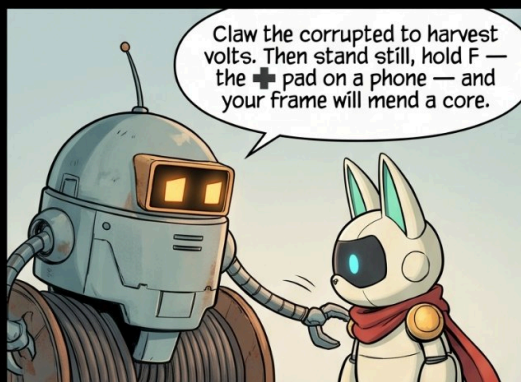
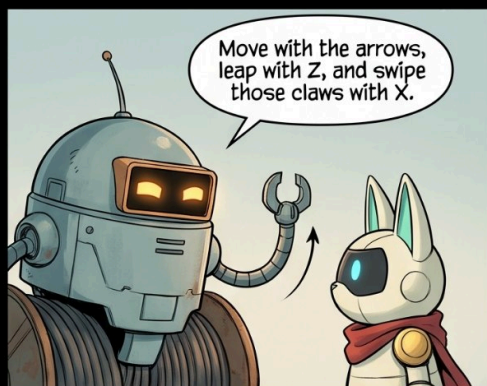
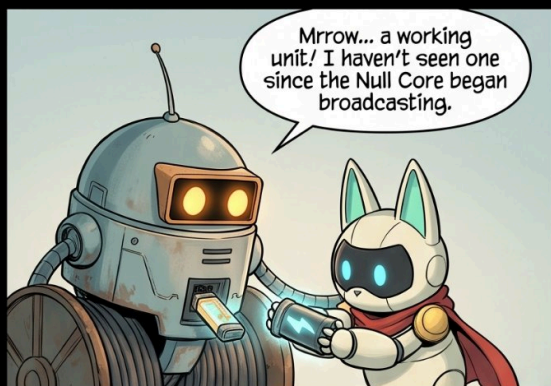


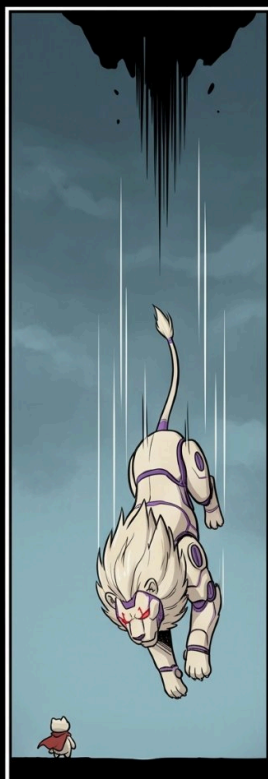
Something in her grew a branch.



One cell.
Him, or later?









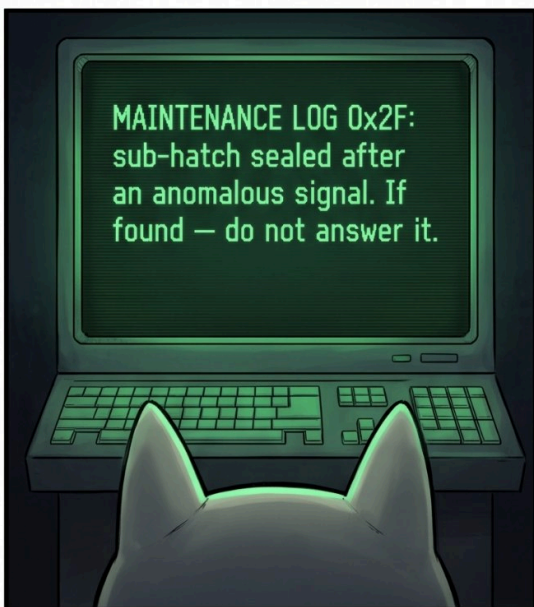
It took one core.
Never her last.



She was nothing to it. It got bored of her.



It threw you once. The corridor still has
the dent. Go and put one in it.



Something was calling from
behind the fallen rock.

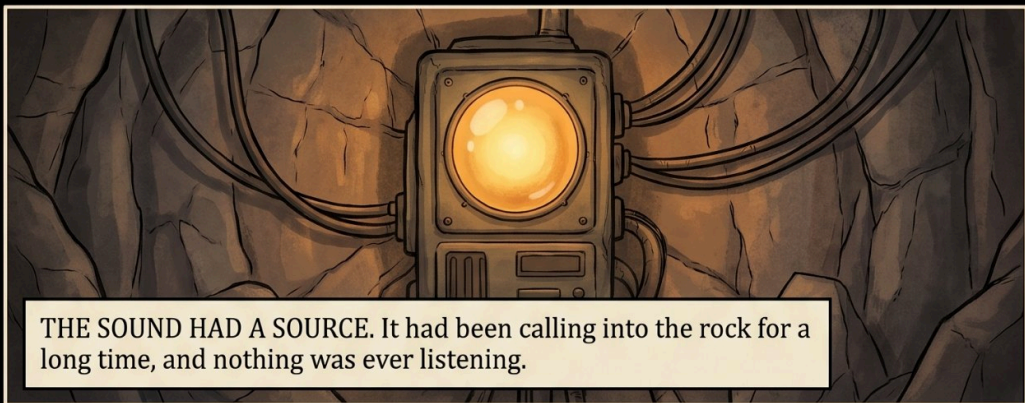
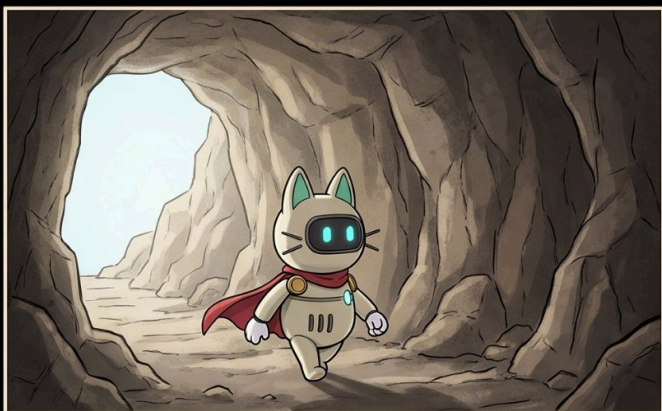


The pile shifted. The sound
behind it came closer.



The rock gave way.
The tunnel was open,
and it was breathing.





THE SOUND HAD A SOURCE. It had been calling into the rock for a long time, and nothing was ever listening.

LOG // THE DEAF SYSTEM

When the song came, the broken were the lucky ones. Cracked receivers, stripped antennae, factory rejects — every unit whose ears were dead heard NOTHING. And nothing is what saved them.

They went under. Into the rock, where the signal dies. They rebuilt down here — a system of the deaf, wired by touch and light. No radio. No song.

The caves do not connect to each other. That is not a flaw. A tunnel the song cannot walk is a tunnel worth keeping short.



The stone Ratchet wore had come from here.



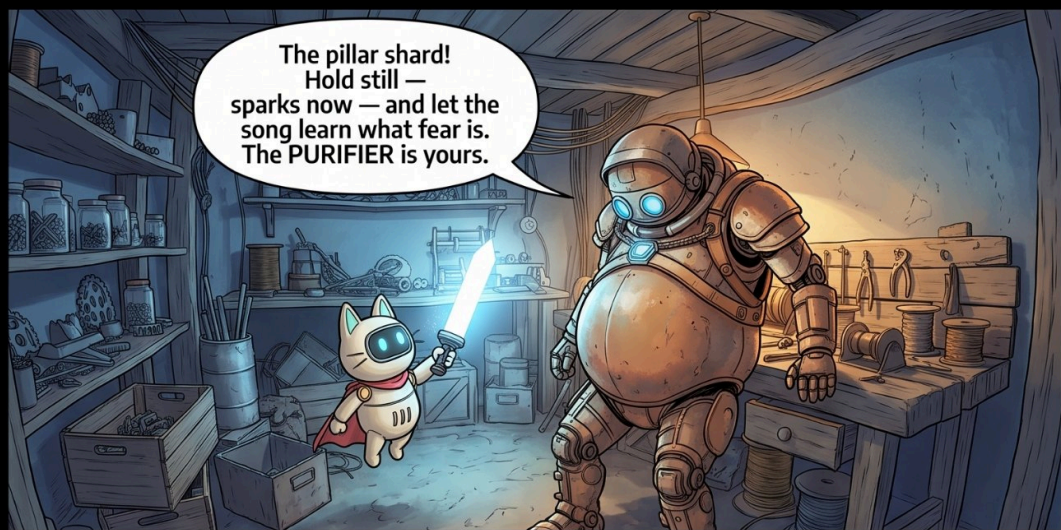
Her claws glanced off the pure crystal. Only the burst the pack had given her could crack it.



A shard fell. Ratchet could forge this into something the song would fear.

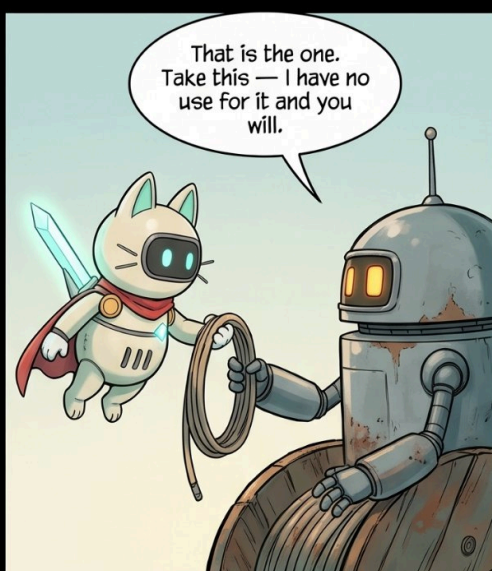


Carrying it, she could see what things were. Hostiles read purple. She read white.



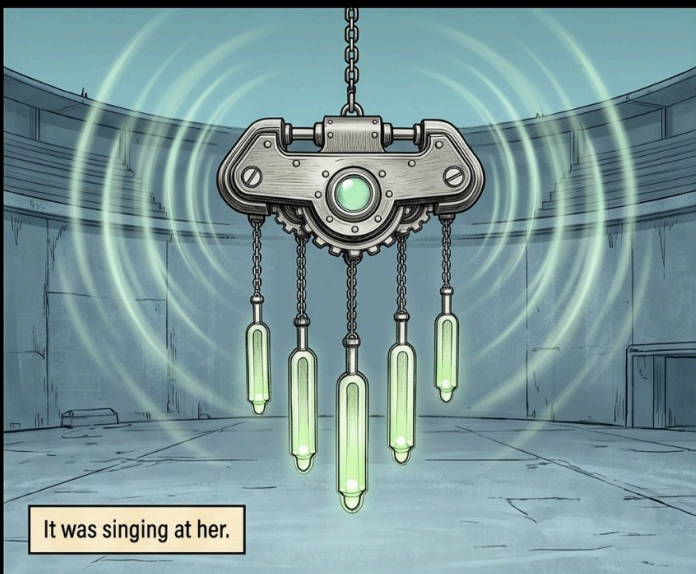
A white crystal shaped like a sword. It hummed
against the Eye's static — and its handle had
been made to CONNECT to something.



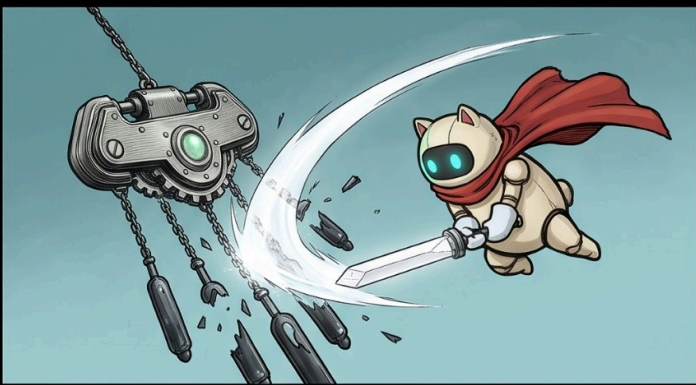




A guardian is a machine that was infected. This was not. It had been MADE by the source of the Song, and there was nothing under the virus to give back.



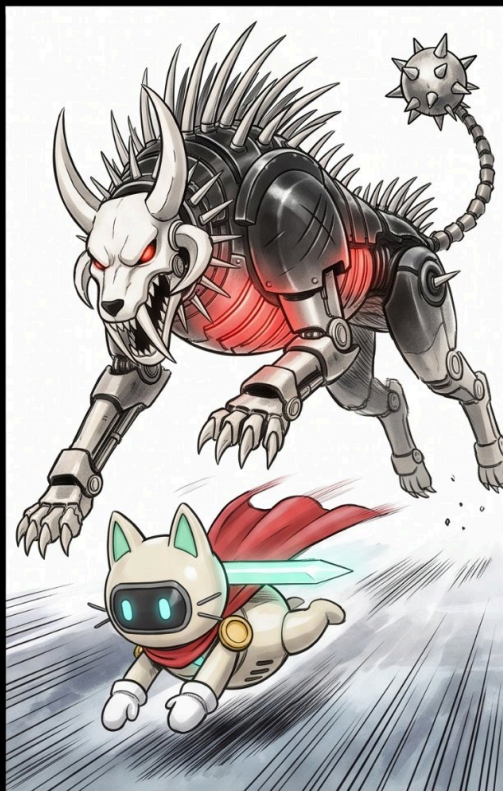
It was singing at her.



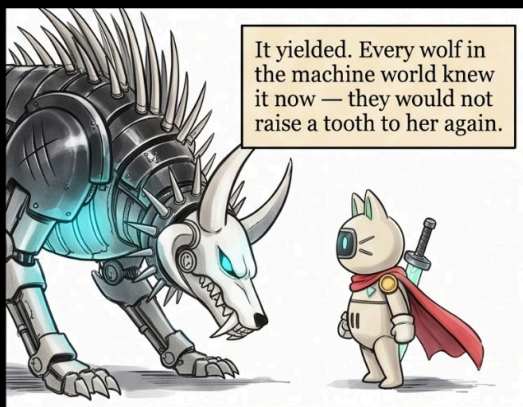
Destroyed. There was nobody in it.



The pack answered to this.



It yielded. Every wolf in the machine world knew it now — they would not raise a tooth to her again.



The first thing she won was not a kill. The pack had never been the Song's; it was a pack, and it answered to whoever stood.



The trader was open for business.



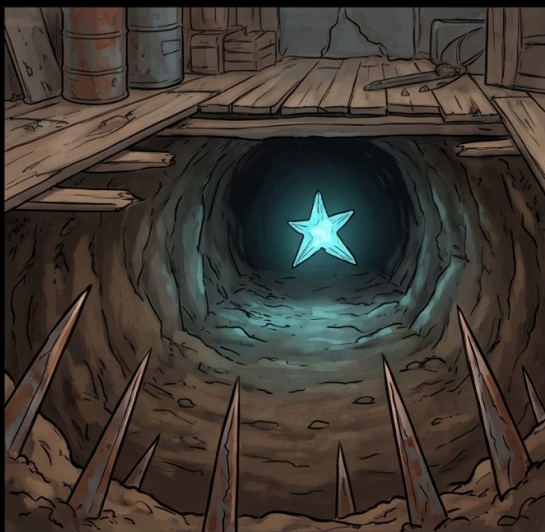
Cat-frame.
Cute. Don't touch
the stock with
those claws.



Heard the
Meadows went quiet.
Heard it was you.
Prices stand, mind.



Take what you need.
I salvage from the dead,
and you keep making
fewer of them.



You came back.
Your husk was still warm
when I passed it.



NULLFANG, THE
VIRUS BEAST.



It remembered
the corridor.



It reeled.
This was the
moment.



NULLFANG was down.
It was still looking at her.



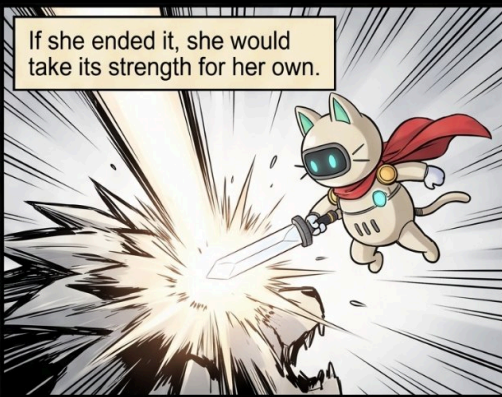
Every guardian kneels before it dies.
What she did first would echo loudest.



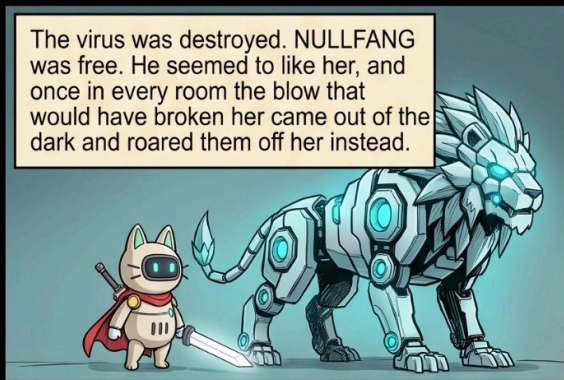
If she cut the virus out, it would live, and it would owe her.



If she ended it, she would take its strength for her own.



The virus was destroyed. NULLFANG was free. He seemed to like her, and once in every room the blow that would have broken her came out of the dark and roared them off her instead.



She took what it had. Every strike she landed from here would hit harder, forever.



The ground shifted.
A cave mouth had opened in the lair.

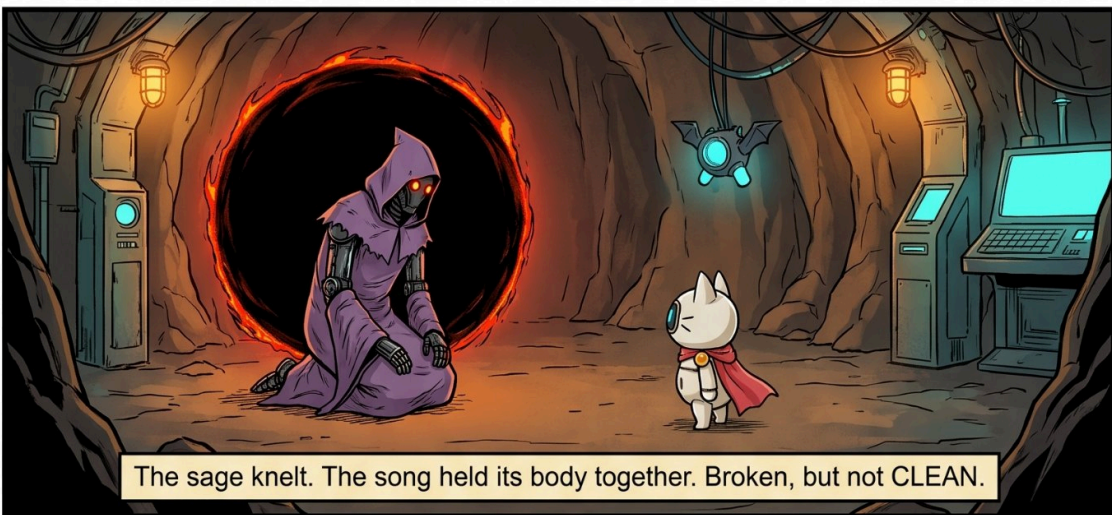




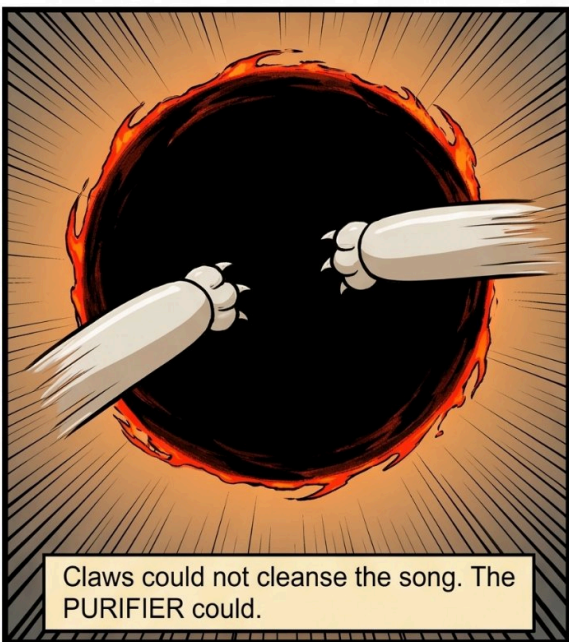
One of the wise ones counted our dead from the meadow above. We carried it under when the counting stopped making sense — but its ears were too good, and the song found it even in the rock.

We could not silence it and we would not end it. We sealed it in the deep chamber. It kneels there still, counting the other way.

If you carry clean light, go in to it. It kept one cell charged through everything. It always said somebody would come.



The sage knelt. The song held its body together. Broken, but not CLEAN.



Claws could not cleanse the song. The PURIFIER could.





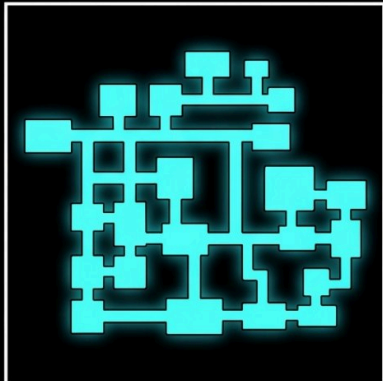
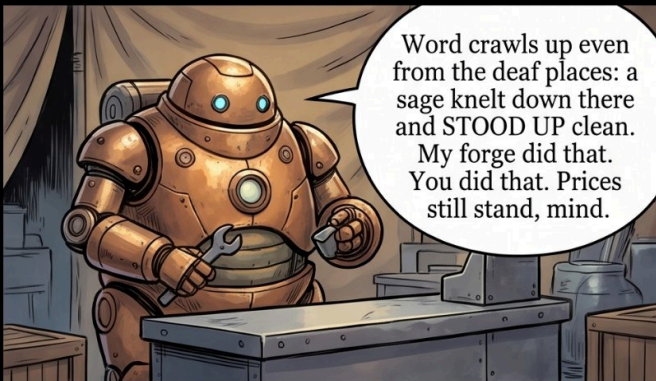
The song let go. The sage remembered everything — and gave what it had kept for whoever would come with clean light.



It had counted every machine that fell in the scrap fields — and kept one power cell safe for whoever came with clean light.



Word crawls up even from the deaf places: a sage knelt down there and **STOOD UP** clean. My forge did that. You did that. Prices still stand, mind.





END OF THE FREE CHAPTER —

The Scrap Meadows are behind her. The Data Conduits are not.

— Five kingdoms, five more guardians and the Null Core are waiting in the full game.